

For Xhenis and  
Petru, because how  
they XPerience  
love and life with  
fierce beauty and  
tender strength  
inspires us all

Life often hits us hard.  
Routine and stress and  
steady erosion shrink us.  
Love is growth as  
counterweight to life's  
evil, but how to feed it?  
This game is one for  
couples that are not too  
weary of a bit of playful  
work and wish to level  
up their marriage game.

## Rule 1

Level up your marriage by talking about the topics on the cards and reaching a common answer. That's it, that is the game!

## Rule 2

When talking about a topic, you only level-up when you reach an answer you are both happy with, and one that you both believe is useful to have articulated. You do not level up if you reach two different answers.

## Rule 3

Every time you get to have a meaningful conversation about your relationship, congratulate yourselves. Take the card and stick it with some magnet to your fridge, as an achievement.

## Rule 4

If you are struggling to pick topics, do it like this. Each pick a color (or the same color). Then draw 3 face-down cards each only from picked colors.

Rock-paper-scissors to decide who goes first. Then the first one picks a topic from their drawn topics.

## Rule 5

You only level up if you do it constantly. Every month with no new talk resets your progress. We advice you set for yourself a recurring date, like the first and third Wed of every month.

## Rule 6

The cards are kinda cool and you can also use them some other way. Actually, on one of the cards you will find a QR code to a lil piece of software that lets you create more cards that you can then print by following the instructions found at the same link.



Make your own cards.

[github.com/  
olaruandreidan/XPCardGame](https://github.com/olaruandreidan/XPCardGame)

What does  
our ideal  
weekday  
morning look  
like, for both  
of us?

How do we  
want to  
spend the  
last twenty  
minutes  
before  
sleep?

How do we  
want to  
handle the  
laundry,  
cooking, and  
errands split  
as our lives  
get busier?

How do we  
want to  
handle  
differing  
sleep  
schedules or  
night-owl  
versus  
early-riser  
habits?

What's our  
rule of thumb  
for big versus  
small  
purchases:  
who decides,  
and at what  
price does it  
become a  
“we”  
decision?

How do we  
recover,  
practically,  
after a  
short-tempered  
moment at  
home?

How do we  
want to use a  
“day off from  
each other”  
without it  
turning into  
avoidance?

What's our  
rule for  
screens,  
gaming, or  
scrolling  
once we're  
both home  
for the  
evening?

What should  
we do when  
one of us  
brings home  
a mood the  
other didn't  
sign up for?

What  
differences in  
our  
temperaments  
have quietly  
turned out to  
be good for us  
rather than a  
problem to  
fix?

A household runs on a lot of invisible work, such as noticing the empty fridge, the overdue bill, remembering the friend who needs checking on, planning the weekend. How do we want to build that noticing together, rather than leaving the invisible burden mostly in one person's head?

What did  
money mean  
in the  
household you  
grew up in  
and how does  
that history  
quietly shape  
how you two  
talk about  
money now?

Who and how  
decides the  
priorities in the  
work that you need  
to get done  
together, if fixing  
the door creek is  
more important  
than going out or  
doing groceries, if  
cleaning the oven  
and not selecting  
the vacation  
destination is how  
we spend the  
afternoon?

Who and how  
decides the level  
of quality that  
needs to be  
reached for  
work you do  
together, be it  
laundry policy,  
how clean the  
fridge should be  
or how to select  
a present for  
common friends?

How do we deal with a situation in which the other does something that we do not like, especially if we are in a social setting or under time pressure?

Children, such  
a scary, yet  
playful  
concept. How  
are we aligned  
on this topic,  
do we want  
children, how  
many, and  
how would we  
raise them?

How do we  
want our  
children  
raised in  
what we  
believe and  
value,  
practically?

How do we  
want to care  
for our  
parents as  
they age?

How do you want to make big career or life decisions together going forward? If one of us gets a call toward a specific vocation or work, how far are we willing to bend our plans to support it?

Where do we  
actually  
want to be  
living in ten  
years?

What does retirement look like for us, and do we picture it the same way?

How do we  
want to  
handle it if  
our incomes  
end up very  
unequal?

What's the  
legacy (not  
financial, the  
actual  
character or  
values) we  
want to  
leave  
behind?

What does a  
“good  
failure” look  
like for us, a  
risk we’d  
respect each  
other for  
taking even  
if it didn’t  
work out?

How do we  
want to keep  
choosing  
each other  
on purpose,  
decade after  
decade,  
rather than  
by default?

If one of us can  
access an  
opportunity,  
cushion, or  
resource the other  
can't, how can we  
use that difference  
in a way that feels  
good to both of us,  
rather than  
something either  
of us feels guilty  
or resentful  
about?

When our families' expectations for us don't match, which parts do we want to keep from each, which do we want to let go of, and what do we want to invent together that's entirely ours?

If we believe  
the other one  
is pouring  
effort into a  
goal that we  
do not agree  
with, how do  
we  
communicate  
that and  
resolve that  
issue?

Where is one  
of us  
stronger than  
the other,  
and how do  
we let that  
carry us both  
instead of  
becoming a  
source of  
resentment?

What does  
love as  
sacrifice  
actually cost  
each of us  
this season,  
concretely?

What's a  
compliment  
or form of  
affection you  
wish I gave  
more often?

How has the  
other person  
changed you  
for the  
better this  
year?

What's a  
small daily  
habit of ours  
that's quietly  
good for the  
marriage,  
and that we  
should  
protect?

What does  
being fully  
present with  
each other  
actually  
require us to  
put down?

What's  
something  
you're proud  
of that you  
don't think  
I've said out  
loud  
recently?

What does  
taking up  
something  
hard  
“together,”  
rather than  
each alone,  
look like for  
us right now?

What's one  
thing about  
how you love  
that I should  
learn to  
receive  
better?

What's a  
version of “I  
love you”,  
not the  
words, but  
an action,  
that actually  
means the  
most to you?

Love can either use people up or genuinely empower them; what makes the difference is mutuality. Describe a recent moment that felt like real, mutual, empowering love. What specifically made it feel that way, and how could we create more moments like it?

Real closeness  
doesn't come from  
becoming the same  
person; it comes  
from staying  
different and  
choosing, again and  
again, to  
understand each  
other across that  
difference. What's a  
difference between  
us that you'd rather  
protect and get  
curious about than  
smooth away?

If physical intimacy is something we're always learning together, what's one thing we'd want to get better at as a team?

What skills  
does each one  
of us want to  
build in order  
to be a better  
partner and  
how do you  
plan on  
empowering  
each other in  
this process?

How do we  
actually want  
to apologize  
to each  
other? What  
makes an  
apology land  
instead of  
just ending  
the  
argument?

What does  
patience  
actually look  
like for us, in  
practice, on  
a bad day?

What's a  
grudge  
either of us  
might still be  
quietly  
carrying, and  
what would  
it take to  
actually let it  
go?

What's  
something I  
do that  
you've never  
told me  
actually  
hurts?

How do we  
want to  
handle it  
when we're  
both right  
and both  
hurt?

How do we  
make sure  
the sun  
doesn't go  
down on an  
unresolved  
fight?

How do we  
want to  
handle  
criticism  
from each  
other  
without it  
turning into  
defense?

How do we  
want to  
handle it  
when one of  
us needs  
comfort and  
the other  
jumps  
straight to  
fixing the  
problem?

If the exact  
situation that  
caused our  
worst fight  
happened  
again  
tomorrow,  
what would  
each of us  
actually do  
differently  
now?

Think about our  
last real  
disagreement.  
What helped us  
find the words  
for what was  
actually wrong?  
How could we  
practice that  
together next  
time, on  
purpose?

Philosopher Ellie Anderson calls the work of figuring out what you're feeling, and helping your partner do the same, hermeneutic labor. Where does that kind of work already flow easily between us? Where would you like to build more of it, on purpose, together?

What often gets called someone's "intuition" in a relationship is really years of unacknowledged interpretive work, such as noticing, translating, and making sense. Is there a kind of understanding one of us seems to have "naturally"? What would it look like to treat that as a skill we're both building, rather than a trait only one of us has?

Describe a moment that felt more one-sided or draining than empowering. Without assigning blame, what would need to shift in either of us, or in how we relate, for a moment like that to feel mutual instead?

What's one  
script about  
how love or  
partnership is  
“supposed” to  
work,  
something you  
inherited rather  
than chose,  
that you've had  
to unlearn  
together?